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Gainward	Mediatech India	022-26361111	digit@mediatechindia.com	www.gainward.de
Gigabyte	Gigabyte Technology (India) Ltd.	91-22-26526696	sales@gigabyte.in	www.gigabyte.in
MaxForce	Maxtone Electronics	022-23016468	maxtone@vsnl.com	www.maxtone.com
MSI	Micro-Star International	011-51758808	info@msi-india.com	www.msi-india.com
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PowerColor	Mediatech India	022-26361111	digit@mediatechindia.com	www.powercolor.com
XFX	Rashi Peripherals	022-28221013	navinderc@rptechindia.com	www.xfxforce.com

Asus Dual VGA/Dual GPU 6800 Ultra 512MB

SLI improves and scales gaming performance. But what if this could be achieved using a single card? What if two GPUs are snug-fit onto a single card?

Remember the Obsidian X-24 in the 3DFX days, which had implemented SLI on a single board with two Voodoo II chips on-board? The Asus Dual VGA 512 MB card does just that. It is, in fact, a chip-level SLI implementation—two GeForce 6800 Ultra chips on a single card, eliminating the need to plug in two cards into two different slots.

You will still need an SLI-capable motherboard to use this card. On a non-SLI motherboard, it will run as a single GeForce 6800 Ultra card.

Each of the GPUs gets only half the total bandwidth and memory of the board, so the 256-bit, 512 MB memory runs as 128-bit 256 MB memory dedicated to two individual GPUs—and hence is not as fast as a 256-bit, 512 MB memory should be. Hence theoretically, in high-bandwidth situations such as 16x AA and 16x AF, the GPUs should become severely memory bandwidth limited.

We tried to test if this was true. At 1,600 x 1,200 in *Doom 3*, *Half-Life 2* and *FarCry*, the frames per second were 122.9, 84.3 and 117.6 respectively. The 3DMark 03 and 3DMark 05 scores were 18547 and 8745 respectively. This card thus performs better than the GeForce 7800 GTX and a bit poorer than the GeForce 6800GT SLI solution in the 3DMark benchmarks, while in the gaming benchmarks it comes third, behind the GeForce 7800 GTX and the GeForce 6800GT SLI—even though this card has two GeForce 6800 Ultra chips onboard.

In a situation involving two GeForce 6800 Ultra cards in SLI configuration, this dual-GPU card will fade into obscurity. Considering the price of Rs 60,320, this card at this moment is not worth considering even if you happen to be the most hardcore of gamers.



Summing It All Up

The XFX video cards dominated the graphics cards comparison. We remember the time last year when XFX made its entry in our comparisons. It was the underdog, and though it showed promise, could not make it to the big league. This time round it took over the show and won four coveted awards, which serve as a benchmark for you, our readers.

None amongst the opposition could stand up to the gauntlet thrown by XFX. Solid build quality and extremely competitive prices made the cards sure-fire winners, and so, this year concludes with XFX and nVidia on top. ATI has a lot of catching up to do, and if the rumour mills are to be believed, the R600 core is what we will be watching out for.

The next time round when we test graphics cards, we will surely be seeing more of nVidia's SLI solutions, as prices are sure to plummet. ATI is also set to bring out its own implementation of multiple-graphics-cards-in-a-system solutions, known as Crossfire, which is touted to be even more flexible than nVidia's SLI: here, you will not be required to have two ATI cards of the exact same model, but you will be able to get away even if the two are of the same series.

Until then, drive rashly, and go on a killing spree (disclaimer: we're talking about computer games!!). ☒

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